suggest that the Quran was a forgery, throw ‘doubts on the authority of prophets and Imams’, utterly deny ‘the existence of demons and angels’, but it did them no good.

They ‘knew nothing of science and had nothing but . . . long tongue[s]’, writes Abul Fazl, enjoying his revenge. The two men protested their banishment as vigorously – or piteously – as they could, but Akbar treated them as good doctors must when they make their patients, ‘willing or unwilling, swallow bitter drugs’. Like it or not, the maulanas were off to Mecca.

On 10 December 1579, Akbar was back from Ajmer, holding court in Fatehpur and sparing not a thought, presumably, for the empty spaces where his wretched clerics must once have stood. It might have been now that Akbar uttered another of his Happy Sayings, dismissing the Devil as ‘an old-world notion’. ‘Who,’ he asked, ‘has the power to oppose the will of God?’

It was only four years earlier that Akbar had prayed on a hard stone outside this very palace, wishing for a pious man to resolve his fears about taking the wrong path. True greatness consists in doing the will of God, he had said, but what if he was following the Devil’s way by mistake? Now, it may be that Akbar had decided to frame the matter in ontological terms rather than moral or ethical ones. That is to say: if, as his question presumes, the will of God is an irresistible force that cannot be challenged – well then, whatever path he was on must be the way of God.

It was no longer musth elephants the emperor was riding, looking for signs of divine approval – he was astride his entire realm, goads in hand, driving it forward. Like it or not.

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Only one month later, the empire bucked.

On 19 January 1580, the feast of Bakrid, when Muslims commemorate the unquestioning submission of Ibrahim to his ineffable deity, Akbar’s officers in Bengal mutinied against their lord.

. Azfar Moin, *The Millennial Sovereign: Sacred Kingship & Sainthood in Islam* (Columbia University Press, 2012).

. Abdul Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh* (Selections from Histories), vol. 2, trans. W.H. Lowe (first published 1884–98; Atlantic Publishers and Distributors, 1990).

. J.F. Richards, ‘The Formulation of Imperial Authority under Akbar and Jahangir’, in *The Mughal*